

20 Most Profitable Movies Of All Time Compared To Budget

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In this article, we will be taking a look at the 20 most profitable movies of all time compared to budget. If you don't want to get into details, then feel free to head straight to the [5 most profitable movies of all time compared to budget](#).

The movie industry is a vibrant and lucrative field that has given birth to some of the most enduring and popular films ever made. When it comes to profitability, a movie's success is heavily influenced by the discrepancy between its box office receipts and its production budget. These movies are characterized by their exceptional ROI, with box office earnings that have significantly exceeded their production costs.

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Some of the most profitable movies of all time include films such as "Avatar," which had a production budget of approximately \$237 million and grossed over \$2.9 billion at the box office, making it the highest-grossing movie of all time, and "Titanic" which had a production budget of \$200 million and grossed over \$2.2 billion at the box office, making it the second-highest-grossing movie of all time.

Large film production companies such as The Walt Disney Company (NYSE:[DIS](#)), that earned a revenue of [\\$84.41 billion](#) in 2022, Warner Bros. Discovery, inc (NASDAQ:[WBD](#)), that earned a revenue of [\\$33.81 billion](#) in 2022, and Universal Pictures, that earned the revenue of [\\$11.62 billion](#) in the same year as well, have been dominating the movie industry for decades. They have been producing some of the most successful films of all time and have had a significant impact on the industry's trends and direction.

In recent years, there have been several consolidations within the film industry. The Walt Disney Company (NYSE:[DIS](#)), for example, has acquired several major entertainment companies, such as Pixar, Marvel, and Lucasfilm, to expand its portfolio and increase its market share. Warner Bros. Discovery, Inc. (NASDAQ:[WBD](#)) has a rich history in Hollywood and is known for producing iconic movies like The Wizard of Oz, Casablanca, and the Harry Potter franchise.

In addition to movies, Warner Bros. Discovery, Inc. (NASDAQ:[WBD](#)) produced popular TV shows such as Friends, The Big Bang Theory, and Riverdale. Warner Bros. Discovery, Inc. (NASDAQ:[WBD](#)) has also merged with AT&T to form a media and entertainment powerhouse,

Warner Media. These consolidations have enabled these companies to produce more films, reach a wider audience, and increase their profitability. They have also allowed these companies to leverage their intellectual property rights, such as popular characters and franchises, to create more successful films.

Industry Outlook

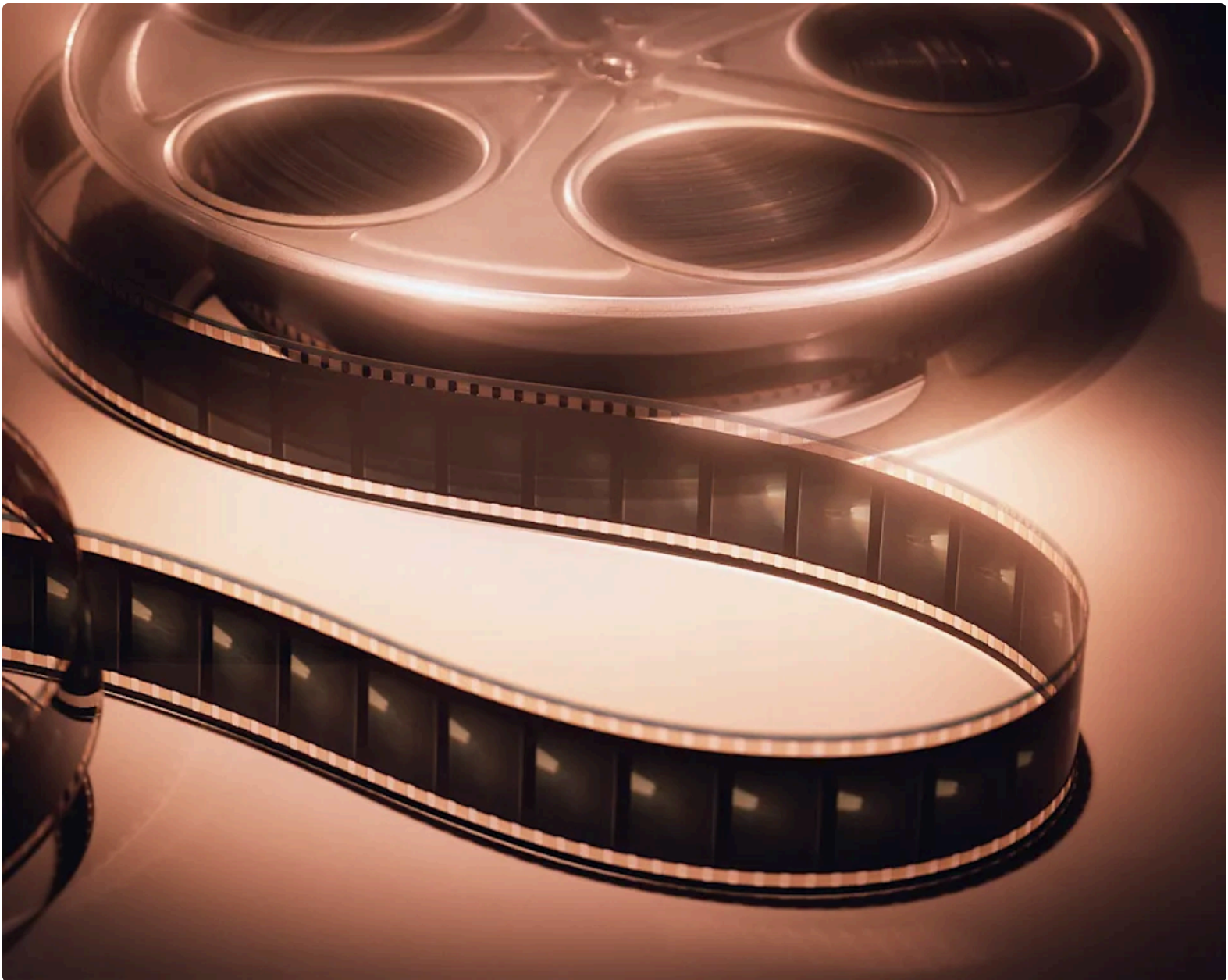
The movie industry outlook is bright, despite the challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic. As theaters continue to reopen and audiences return to the big screen, there is optimism for the industry's recovery. Different film markets saw differing degrees of recovery, as countries all over the world started to ease the movement constraints imposed by the COVID-19 pandemic.

Global box office receipts increased by more than [80%](#) to \$21.3 billion in 2021. However, this amount is hardly half of the \$42.3 billion outcome seen in 2019 prior to the pandemic. In addition, the growth of streaming services like Netflix, Inc. (NASDAQ:[NFLX](#)), Amazon.com, Inc. (NASDAQ:[AMZN](#))'s Prime Video, and The Walt Disney (NYSE:DIS)'s Disney+ presents new opportunities for film distribution and audience engagement.

Netflix, Inc. (NASDAQ:NFLX) initially started as a DVD-by-mail service, but it has since evolved into a global entertainment giant. Netflix, Inc. (NASDAQ:NFLX) has revolutionized the way people consume media, allowing them to watch their favorite content whenever and wherever they want.

Similarly, Amazon.com, Inc. (NASDAQ:AMZN)'s Prime Video has gained popularity due to its extensive library of content, including award-winning original series like The Marvelous Mrs. Maisel, and The Man in the High Castle. Amazon.com, Inc. (NASDAQ:AMZN)'s Prime Video is a great choice for those looking for a diverse selection of entertainment content at an affordable price.

The industry is also experiencing a shift towards more diverse and inclusive content, with a growing demand for films that accurately represent underrepresented communities. Technological advancements, such as virtual reality and artificial intelligence, offer new avenues for storytelling and audience engagement.



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Our Methodology

Our methodology for creating the list of top 20 movies of all time compared to budget involved analyzing data on movie budgets and box office revenues. We have compiled a list of movies with the highest profit-to-budget ratios, with low-budget films that generated highest profits receiving priority. To ensure accuracy, we have collected the data from various sources including [wrapbook](#) and [Collider](#) among others.

Here is our list of 20 most profitable movies compared to budget.

20. Another Earth (2011)

Profit: \$1,900,000 Budget: \$100,000

Mike Cahill's science fiction drama movie, Another Earth, budgeted at \$100,000 came out in 2011. In the movie, Rhoda, a young woman, falls in love with a man whose family was destroyed in a horrific accident that she caused. The discovery of a mirror Earth that emerges in the sky is the main plot device of the movie. The film Another Earth received appreciation for its challenging subjects and potent performances by its leading men, and earned a total profit of \$1,900,000.

19. She's Gotta Have It (1986)

Profit: \$7,100,000 Budget: \$175,000

She's Gotta Have It is a 1986 romantic comedy-drama film, directed by Spike Lee. The focus of the movie is Nola Darling, a young, independent lady living in Brooklyn, who is juggling three suitors. The film examines issues of gender, ethnicity, and sexuality and offers a nuanced look at contemporary relationships. The movie, which was shot in black and white, has a distinctive visual aesthetic and a standout soundtrack that includes songs by artists like Prince and Public Enemy. She's Gotta Have It, which was made on a low budget in just 12 days, is still regarded as a cult classic of independent film, and has served as an inspiration to several generations of filmmakers.

18. Slacker (1990)

Profit: \$1,280,000 Budget: \$23,000

Richard Linklater's groundbreaking independent film, *Slacker*, budgeted at \$23,000 was released in 1991. There are numerous characters that are followed throughout Austin, Texas, in a sequence of connected vignettes. The movie doesn't have a conventional plot; instead, it concentrates on ideas like boredom, apathy, and the quest for meaning, and made a total profit of \$1,280,000. The movie has influenced independent filmmaking because of its naturalistic aesthetic, non-actors it uses, and extended takes. With its long-lasting effects on Austin's cultural fabric, *Slacker* has aided Linklater in becoming a significant filmmaker.

17. Pi (1998)

Profit: \$4,678,513 Budget: \$68,000

Darren Aronofsky directed the independent psychological thriller movie *Pi* in 1998. The story follows mathematician Max Cohen as he looks for a numerical pattern that will reveal the universe's mysteries. Max enters a frightening world of corporate espionage, religious fanaticism, and mental instability as a result of his pursuit. Intensely examining obsession and madness, *Pi* is renowned for its outstanding visual design, unique story structure, and strong themes. The movie was budgeted at \$68,000 but earned a profit of [\\$4,678,513](#), which is huge.

16. The Birth Of A Nation (1915)

Profit: \$11,000,000 Budget: \$110,000

D.W. Griffith's 1915 silent film, The Birth of a Nation depicts the tale of the Civil War and Reconstruction through the perspectives of two families. The movie has received a lot of negative attention and condemnation because of its racial content. Despite its technical and creative breakthroughs, The Birth Of A Nation managed to earn a profit of [\\$11,000,000](#).

15. Catfish (2010)

Profit: \$3,500,000 Budget: \$30,000

The documentary Catfish was produced in 2010 by Henry Joost and Ariel Schulman. The movie follows Nev Schulman, Schulman's brother, as he forms an internet connection with Megan. Nev grows dubious of Megan's identity as the couple gets closer and starts looking into it. Catfish has received high praise for its honesty and genuineness as it explores the nature of identity and relationships in the digital era, making the profit of \$3,500,000.

14. Clerks (1994)

Profit: \$4,400,000 Budget: \$27,000

Clerks is a 1994 independent comedy film, directed by Kevin Smith. The film follows a day in the life of two store clerks, Dante and Randal, as they navigate their dead-end jobs and interact with a cast of eccentric characters. Shot in black and white on a shoestring budget of \$27,000, Clerks was a critical and commercial success, making a profit of \$4,400,000, launching Smith's career as a filmmaker and becoming a cult classic. The film is known for its witty dialogue, memorable characters, and irreverent humor.

13. Halloween (1978)

Profit: \$70,000,000 Budget: \$325,000

Halloween, budgeted at \$325,000, is a 1978 horror film directed by John Carpenter. The film follows the iconic killer Michael Myers as he escapes from a psychiatric hospital and stalks a group of teenagers on Halloween night. The film's atmospheric cinematography, chilling soundtrack, and unforgettable villain have made it a classic of the horror genre. Halloween has inspired numerous sequels and remakes, and cemented its place in pop culture as a quintessential Halloween movie.

12. Night Of The Living Dead (1968)

Profit: \$30,000,000 Budget: \$114,000

The 1968 horror movie, Night of the Living Dead, was directed by George A. Romero. The movie centers on a group of strangers who hide out in a farmhouse to avoid being attacked by flesh-eating zombies, and was innovative for its depiction of blood and guts as well as its comments on racial tensions and socioeconomic issues. The zombie films and TV shows that have come after Night of the Living Dead are considered cult classics of horror cinema.

11. El Mariachi (1992)

Profit: \$2,000,000 Budget: \$7000

Robert Rodriguez's 1992 independent film, El Mariachi was released in theatres. A travelling musician who is mistaken for a murderer and drawn into a web of violence and mistaken identification is the subject of the movie. El Mariachi barely costed \$7,000 to produce and was filmed over the course of two weeks. Rodriguez's career was boosted by the movie's success, which has subsequently made it a cult favorite in the action-thriller genre.

10. Super Size Me (2004)

Profit: \$22,200,000 Budget: \$65,000

The documentary *Super Size Me* was released in 2004, and was directed and starred by Morgan Spurlock. Spurlock's 30-day experiment to consume solely McDonald's cuisine, three times a day, is followed in the movie. The documentary investigates how fast food affects health and how the fast food industry has an impact on American culture. The movie's critical and financial success of \$22,200,000 sparked a heated public debate about fast food and prompted changes in the fast food business, such as the elimination of McDonald's "super size" menu item.

9. The Brothers Mc Mullen (1995)

Profit: \$10,000,000 Budget: \$28,000

The 1995 romantic comedy-drama movie, *Brother McMullen* was written, produced, and directed by Edward Burns. The movie follows three Irish-American brothers as they manage their relationships with women and their beliefs while living on Long Island, New York. The film, which was shot on a tight budget, won praise for its realistic dialogue and accurate depiction of Irish-American society, earning the profit of \$10,000,000. The endearing and witty movie, *Brother McMullen* helped Burns establish his career as a filmmaker by examining themes of love, faith, and family from a novel angle.

8. Facing The Giants (2006)

Profit: \$38,551,255 Budget: \$100,000

Facing the Giants is a 2006 sports drama film, directed by and starring Alex Kendrick. The film follows a high school football coach who turns to God when his team begins to struggle, and explores themes of faith, perseverance, and overcoming adversity. Despite its low budget and amateur cast, the film was a commercial success and received positive reviews for its inspirational message, and heartwarming story.

7. Open Water (2003)

Profit: \$55,500,000 Budget: \$120,000

Open Water is a 2003 horror film directed by Chris Kentis. The film follows a couple who become stranded in the middle of the ocean during a scuba diving trip, and must fight for survival against sharks and other dangers. The film's low budget and documentary-style

approach lend it a sense of realism and tension, and its portrayal of the terrifying vastness of the ocean has made it a cult classic of the horror genre.

6. Mad Max (1979)

Profit: 99,750,000 Budget: \$200,000

Mad Max is a 1979 action film directed by George Miller. The film is set in a post-apocalyptic Australia, where a police officer named Max (played by Mel Gibson) seeks revenge against a violent motorcycle gang. The film's gritty, violent, and visually stunning depiction of a dystopian future has made it a cult classic of the action genre. Mad Max has since spawned multiple sequels and reboots, solidifying its place in pop culture history, making a profit of \$99,750,000.

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